

"WE NOW WANT ONLY A FINAL SOLUTION"



Photographs by J. SUDATH SILVA

In the past few months, Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapakse seems to have come into his own. His defence forces are notching up successes against the LTTE, he has fended off attempts to have his Government defeated in Parliament and is one step ahead of his rivals by announcing a devolution package for the Tamils. In an exclusive interview in his Temple Trees office in the heart of Colombo, a confident Rajapakse spoke to Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA about what he sees as the challenges ahead. Excerpts:

Q. Do you want to get Prabhakaran dead or alive?

A. Alive. For the crimes he has done, he needs to be tried and I would like to send him to India too for he killed a leader who would have changed the face of not just India but the whole region.

Q. Why did you decide finally to end the five-year-old Ceasefire Agreement (CFA) between the Government and the LTTE?

A. When the CFA was introduced in 2002, I was leader of the Opposition and the first one to speak out against

it. When I became the President, I said I will try to negotiate with the LTTE, talk to them and achieve peace to settle the issue. But it did not mean that I approved of the CFA. But they went on a killing spree, not only attacking our army commander, the defence secretary, who is my brother, but also began targeting civilians and children. I wanted the killing to stop. They had violated the CFA so often that it had become a farce. So I decided to end it.

Q. What makes you so confident of taking on the LTTE in an all out war now?

A. Either the LTTE accept a political solution by giving up arms and terrorist activities or we will have to curtail their moves. The Government

"The ceasefire was a farce. Only if the LTTE gives up its weapons are we willing to negotiate with them."

can't kneel down to terrorists. Since I came to power we have cleared the eastern and western provinces of LTTE control. They are now restricted to just one-and-a-half districts. From top to bottom the Government is committed. There is greater coordination between the Government and the defence forces which helps our cause.

Q. If the LTTE comes back to the negotiating table, will you talk?

A. Yes, only if they give up their weapons. They can't have their cake and eat it too. Ceasefire will give them time again. We don't want them to